



A FIELD GUIDE • COMPANION TO THE BOOK

Grow Your Digital Garden

The action steps from every chapter — one season of work, broken into small things you can do this week.

FIFTEEN TASKS • FIVE SEASONS • ONE GARDEN

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You don't grow a following. You grow a community.

Most local business owners treat social media like a billboard. They shout into it, and then wonder why the phone never rings. But a garden has never once grown because someone stood over it and yelled. It grows because someone *shows up, tends it, and genuinely cares about what's living in it.*

This guide pulls the single most important action out of every chapter of *The Digital Garden* and sets it in front of you, plainly. No theory. Just the doing. Choose a chapter, do the task this week, and come back for the next. That is how any garden gets planted — one quiet row at a time.

WHAT'S INSIDE

Each chapter gives you one Garden Task for the week and two or three steps to make it real. Fifteen chapters, grouped into five seasons of growth.

HOW TO USE IT

You don't need all fifteen at once. One a week, and in about three months you'll have a garden that quietly feeds your business.

WHERE TO GO DEEPER

The note at the foot of each chapter points you to where the full story and the why behind it live in the book.

THE FIVE SEASONS



I

Preparing the Soil

Before you plant anything, get the ground right.

CH 1 - 3



II

Planting Seeds

Your first real connections — and showing up like a human.

CH 4 - 6



III

Watering Consistently

The daily habits that make audiences — and relationships — grow.

CH 7 - 9



IV

Managing the Weeds

Vanity metrics, comparison, and the traps that quietly kill growth.

CH 10 - 12



V

The Harvest

How real community turns into referrals, clients, and trust.

CH 13 - 15



PART ONE

Preparing the Soil

Nothing grows in ground you haven't prepared. Before the first post, get clear on why you're here and where you'll plant.

CHAPTER ONE

Stop Broadcasting, Start Belonging

What most people get wrong — treating your page like a megaphone instead of a front porch.

THE WORK

- 01 For one week, **comment on three other people's posts before you publish your own**. Belonging comes before broadcasting.
- 02 Audit your last ten posts. Count how many **asked something** of the reader versus simply announced something. Flip the ratio.
- 03 Reply to **every** comment and message within 24 hours this week — like a neighbor, not a brand.



THIS WEEK

Leave a genuine comment on **five posts** from local businesses or people you admire — no pitch, just presence.

IN THE BOOK The full porch-versus-billboard story opens Chapter 1.

CHAPTER TWO

Know Your Why Before You Plant Anything

What most people get wrong — posting tactics with no reason underneath them, so nothing ever connects.

THE WORK

- 01 Write one sentence: "**I show up online because** _____. If it stops at "to get clients," dig one layer deeper.
- 02 Name the **one person** you're really talking to — their age, their town, what keeps them up at night. Post to that person.
- 03 Keep your why where you'll see it before you post. Every piece of content should serve it.



THIS WEEK

Write your **one-sentence why** and your one-person reader on a card. Put it where you'll see it before you post.

IN THE BOOK Chapter 2 walks through finding the why beneath the why.

CHAPTER THREE

Choosing Your Platform — The Right Soil for Your Seeds

What most people get wrong — trying to be everywhere at once, and doing all of it badly.

THE WORK

- 01 Pick **one platform** where your actual customers already spend time. For most local businesses, that's Facebook or Instagram.
- 02 Go all-in there for ninety days before adding a second. **Depth beats spread.**
- 03 Pause the ghost-town accounts that do nothing but make you feel behind.



THIS WEEK

Choose your **one home platform** and commit to it out loud — tell someone. That's your plot of soil.

IN THE BOOK Chapter 3 has the platform-by-business-type breakdown.



PART TWO

Planting Seeds

A seed is just a real connection. You plant them one conversation at a time, as yourself — not as a logo.

CHAPTER FOUR

The First Conversation, Without Feeling Weird

What most people get wrong — sliding into messages with a sales pitch instead of a real hello.

THE WORK

- 01 Start **three conversations** this week with no agenda — a real question, a real compliment, a real "how's business?"

- 02 When someone engages with you, **engage back the same day**. A reply is a handshake.
- 03 Keep a short list of local people you'd like to know, and show up in their comments first.



THIS WEEK

Send **three no-pitch messages or comments** that genuinely start a conversation.

IN THE BOOK Chapter 4 gives you the exact openers that don't feel salesy.

CHAPTER FIVE

Your Story Is the Seed

What most people get wrong — *hiding behind the logo because "nobody cares about my story."* They do.

THE WORK

- 01 Write down the **origin story** of your business — why you started, and what you walked away from to do it.
- 02 Find the **one story you've never posted** because it felt too small. That's usually the one that lands.
- 03 Turn it into a single honest post. No polish required — just true.



THIS WEEK

Write the **one story** about your business you've never told online — then post it.

IN THE BOOK Chapter 5 shows how Jayson's "started over" story became his best content.

CHAPTER SIX

Show Up as a Person, Not a Logo

What most people get wrong — *polishing the brand until every post sounds like a robot wrote it.*

THE WORK

- 01 Put **your actual face** in your content this week — a short video, a photo, a behind-the-scenes moment.
- 02 Share one thing that **isn't** a sale: a lesson, a near-miss, an ordinary Tuesday at the shop.
- 03 Write the way you talk. Read the caption out loud — if you wouldn't say it over coffee, rewrite it.



THIS WEEK

Post **one piece of content** with your real face and your real voice in it.



PART THREE

Watering Consistently

Gardens don't grow on intensity. They grow on the small, boring habit of showing up — a little, every day.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The 10-Minute Daily Habit That Changes Everything

What most people get wrong — going viral for a day, then disappearing for three weeks.

THE WORK

- 01 Block **ten minutes a day** at the same time — coffee in hand — to engage before you create.
- 02 Spend them simply: five comments, two replies, one share of someone else's good work.
- 03 Track it for fourteen days. **Consistency, not intensity**, grows the garden.



THIS WEEK

Set a daily **ten-minute timer** and run the five-two-one routine every weekday.

IN THE BOOK Chapter 7 lays out the full ten-minute watering routine.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Engagement Is Not Optional

What most people get wrong — posting and ghosting, then blaming the algorithm.

THE WORK

- 01 Treat **every comment like a customer at your counter**. Answer as if they're standing in front of you.
- 02 End your posts with a real question — then actually reply to the answers.
- 03 Spend more time in **other people's** comment sections than in your own.



THIS WEEK

Reply to **100% of the comments and messages** you receive. No exceptions.

CHAPTER NINE

AI as a Garden Tool, Not a Replacement for the Gardener

What most people get wrong — letting AI write everything until it all sounds like nobody.

THE WORK

- 01 Use AI to **save time, not replace your voice** — drafts, ideas, outlines. You add the human.
- 02 Pick one chore — captions, repurposing, scheduling — and let a tool handle it this week.
- 03 Never publish anything you wouldn't say yourself. **Edit it back into your own accent.**



THIS WEEK

Use AI to draft **five post ideas**, then rewrite the best one fully in your own voice.

IN THE BOOK Chapter 9: "Human Focused, AI Optimized" — what that actually means.



PART FOUR

Managing the Weeds

Some things grow that you never planted. Comparison, vanity metrics, and quiet doubt all choke a garden if you let them.

CHAPTER TEN

Likes Are Not Love

What most people get wrong — chasing the like count while ignoring the people who'd actually buy.

THE WORK

- 01 Pick **one metric that matters**: messages started, calls booked, conversations had. Watch that instead.
- 02 Stop posting for applause. Post for the **one person** who needs to hear it today.
- 03 Once a week, write down the real wins — a reply, a referral, a "saw your post and called."



THIS WEEK

Choose **one meaningful metric** and stop checking likes for seven days.

IN THE BOOK Chapter 10 names the vanity metrics worth pulling like weeds.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Comparison Trap

What most people get wrong — *measuring their season one against someone else's season ten.*

THE WORK

- 01 **Mute or unfollow** the accounts that make you feel behind instead of inspired.
- 02 Keep a wins note on your phone, and compare yourself only to **you, ninety days ago**.
- 03 When envy hits, turn it into a comment — go support the very person you're comparing yourself to.



THIS WEEK

Mute five accounts that drain you, and start a running list of your own wins.

IN THE BOOK Chapter 11: every garden grows on its own clock.

CHAPTER TWELVE

What to Do When Nothing Seems to Be Working

What most people get wrong — *quitting in the quiet stretch, right before the roots take hold.*

THE WORK

- 01 Check the **basics** first: are you showing up consistently, engaging, talking to a real person?
- 02 Return to **conversations** — direct messages and comments grow even when the feed feels flat.
- 03 Give it a full season before you change the whole strategy. Roots grow where you can't see them.



THIS WEEK

Instead of a new strategy, double down on conversations — **start five this week**.

IN THE BOOK Chapter 12 is the pep talk for the dormant season.



PART FIVE

The Harvest

A well-tended garden eventually feeds you. This is where trust quietly turns into clients, referrals, and word of mouth.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

When Fans Become Customers

What most people get wrong — *never actually inviting people to buy, or pitching far too soon.*

THE WORK

- 01 Make a **clear, simple offer** to the people already paying attention. Warm soil grows fast.
- 02 Give value first, then invite — the give, give, give, then ask rhythm.
- 03 Make it **easy to say yes**: one link, one next step, no friction.



THIS WEEK

Make **one clear, friendly offer** to your audience — and tell them exactly how to take you up on it.

IN THE BOOK Chapter 13 shows the moment a fan is ready to become a client.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Referral Loop

What most people get wrong — *hoping for referrals instead of making them easy to give.*

THE WORK

- 01 Spotlight your **customers and other local businesses** in public. Generosity is the seed of every referral.
- 02 Ask your happiest clients for a quick word — and make it effortless for them to give.
- 03 Send people business when you can. A garden grows when the gardeners help each other.



THIS WEEK

Publicly spotlight one happy customer or a local business you love.

IN THE BOOK Chapter 14 maps the loop that turns trust into word of mouth.

Your Garden Never Really Finishes Growing

What most people get wrong — treating social media like a project to finish instead of a garden to tend.

THE WORK

- 01 Build a **simple weekly rhythm** you can keep forever — not a sprint you'll abandon by spring.
- 02 Once a quarter, look back at how far the garden has come. Then plant the next row.
- 03 Keep caring about the people in it. That part never goes out of season.



THIS WEEK

Write down the **weekly rhythm** you can actually sustain — and put it on the calendar.

IN THE BOOK Chapter 15, and the epilogue, are about tending the garden for the long haul.



KEEP GROWING

**This was the map.
The book is the journey.**

You have the action steps now. *The Digital Garden* gives you the stories underneath them — and the why behind every task in this guide. If these steps helped, the book will take you the rest of the way.

CONTINUE WITH THE BOOK

The Digital Garden

Now go water something.

— Jayson Hines